PhD Position in Political Science (MSCA Doctoral Network DIViNE): Democratic Decline, Political Violence, and Cycles of Repression (DC9)

- EURAXESS Job Offer: https://euraxess.ec.europa.eu/jobs/472198

Offer Description

The Department of Social Sciences at Universidad Carlos III de Madrid (UC3M) is looking for a PhD candidate to join the Doctoral Network "Democratic Institutions and Violence Network in Europe" (DIViNE), funded by the EU Horizon Europe Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions (MSCA) programme. Dr. Francisco Villamil (UC3M) and Dr. Brian J. Phillips (University of Essex) will supervise the candidate, who will join a network of 10 PhD candidates across five European universities.

DIViNE brings together leading European research environments: UvA (Amsterdam), UESSEX (Essex), UMIL (Milan), UC3M (Carlos III de Madrid) and UU (Uppsala). It also involves partner organisations, including the Max Planck Institute for Political and Social Science, CIDOB, Fondazione Giangiacomo Feltrinelli, ICIP, International IDEA, Clingendael and Action on Armed Violence (AOAV). Together they combine complementary strengths in quantitative conflict research, behavioural and experimental methods, historical and archival inquiry, institutional and normative theory, and applied policy engagement.

The DIViNE network

Democracies are commonly seen as able to channel contestation through institutionalised processes and nonviolent action. Yet democratic polities frequently experience a broad range of political violence, from riots and organised electoral intimidation to extremist mobilisation and criminal violence. This violence can test, and at times erode, democratic norms and institutions. Democracies may also respond to perceived threats with measures that threaten core features of liberal democracy, such as the rule of law, civil liberties and institutional impartiality. Examples include militarised policing, emergency legislation and selective repression. DIViNE consolidates comparative, historical, theoretical and methodological strands to build a coherent new research programme on political violence in democracies.

The PhD project

The PhD project, "Democratic Decline, Political Violence, and Cycles of Repression", investigates the endogenous relationship between democratic decline and political violence. It analyses how violent protests, terrorism and criminal activity generate pressures for securitisation, and how democratic crackdowns may in turn provoke further dissident violence. It also considers how organised crime interacts with weak or declining democratic institutions, particularly in fragile or post-conflict settings. The research will combine event-level violence data, comparative historical analysis and case studies (e.g. Italy, Northern Ireland) to identify the mechanisms that trigger self-reinforcing cycles of repression and resistance. The project will provide actionable insights on how to prevent and reverse such spirals. The candidate will be free to develop their own project within these parameters.

The candidate will receive interdisciplinary training across Madrid and Essex in democratic backsliding, political violence, terrorism and comparative politics. The doctoral trajectory includes a research stay at the University of Essex. It also includes a non-academic secondment at CIDOB (Barcelona Centre for International Affairs), which will provide opportunities for policy-oriented research, policy engagement and strategic communication.

The candidate will:

- Be enrolled in the UC3M PhD Programme in Social Sciences and take part in its training activities. Your academic work is to result in a doctoral thesis defended at UC3M.
- Take an active part in DIViNE network activities, including training modules, PhD colloquia, research workshops, secondments and summer schools.
- Carry out an academic research stay at the University of Essex and a non-academic secondment at CIDOB (Barcelona).
- Take an active part in the research environment of the Department of Social Sciences, including its seminar series, the annual PhD workshop and the activities of the Juan Linz Institute.
- Co-author publications with other project members and contribute to dissemination and outreach.
- Assist with project-related activities, such as organising workshops or other network events.

What we offer

A full-time employment contract at UC3M for 36 months, under the MSCA Doctoral Network employment conditions. Remuneration according to MSCA rules. For Spain, the EU contribution is €3,833.56 per month (living allowance) plus €710 per month (mobility allowance), plus €495 per month (family allowance) for researchers who are married, in a registered partnership or have dependent children. These amounts are the total employment cost: the employer's social security contributions, the employee's contributions and income tax are deducted from them. The resulting gross salary is approximately €3,300–3,500 per month, depending on personal circumstances. Office space, IT resources and full access to the UC3M library and research facilities. A structured training programme across the DIViNE network, a Personal Career Development Plan, and joint supervision by two universities. Support with administrative procedures related to recruitment, including PhD admission and, where applicable, visa and residence permits. UC3M holds the HR Excellence in Research award and follows the European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for the Recruitment of Researchers. We are committed to gender balance and diversity, and we welcome applications from candidates of any gender, background and life experience.

Requirements

- A Master's degree (EQF level 7) or equivalent in political science or a closely related social science discipline (e.g. sociology, economics, economic history, public administration), giving access to doctoral studies. Bachelor's and Master's studies together must amount to at least 300 ECTS (or equivalent). The degree must have been obtained by the start of employment.
- At least 18 ECTS (or equivalent) in advanced social research methods during your Master's studies.
- A good command of social science research methods, including quantitative methods (e.g. regression analysis of cross-national data, causal inference designs, statistical programming in R/Stata/Python) and/or qualitative and comparative case-study methods.
- Advanced English (C1 level of the CEFR), certified by an official certificate. Applicants who completed secondary education at an English-speaking institution, or a higher education degree of at least two years taught entirely in English, are exempt from the certificate.
- Independent thinking, critical analytical skills, and the ability to work both independently and in a team.

MSCA eligibility requirements:

- *Mobility rule*: Candidates must not have resided or carried out their main activity (work, studies, etc.) in Spain for more than 12 months in the 36 months immediately before the recruitment date. Compulsory national service, short stays such as holidays, and time spent as part of a procedure for obtaining refugee status under the Geneva Convention are not taken into account.
- *Doctoral status*: Candidates must not hold a doctoral degree at the date of recruitment.
- *Nationality*: Candidates may be of any nationality.
- *Admission and enrolment*: The selected candidate must meetthe admission requirements of the UC3M PhD Programme in Social Sciences by the start date of the contract. UC3M will guide the candidate through this process.

How to apply

Please submit the following documents:

1. CV, including names and contact details of two academic referees
2. Cover letter (max. 2 pages) explaining your motivation and preparation for this position
3. Research proposal (max. 3 pages, excluding references) outlining a PhD project that fits the parameters described above
4. Transcripts of your past studies (unofficial copies are fine at this stage)
5. A writing sample (max. 10 pages, this can be an excerpt from a longer text, such as a Master's thesis)

Applications must be submitted through the UC3M online application form: - https://aplicaciones.uc3m.es/formulario/DIVine_doctoral

Only complete applications received by the deadline will be considered. Recommendation letters will be requested only from shortlisted candidates. Candidates applying to several DIViNE positions must apply separately to each recruiting institution.

Selection process

A selection committee including the supervisors of the position will assess applications on the basis of the candidates' academic record, the quality of the research proposal and its fit with the project, and their suitability for the position as described above. Shortlisted candidates will be invited to an online interview during the week of 23–27 November 2026.

Additional comments

For questions about this position, please use this contact form. More information about the network is available at divine.unimi.it.